Main Assignment 1

For MA1, you will work in teams and pretend to work for a new international non-governmental organization (NGO) that seeks to promote awareness of global issues, engage in advocacy, and propose policy solutions (if you don't know what an NGO is, here's a list of the top 15 in the world).

Because it is new, the founders of this NGO have yet to decide on their area of focus. They know they want to specialize in *three* issues, and they are open to either a global, regional, or country-specific focus for each. They have hired you to offer guidance.

You're going to help by using data to show the leaders of this NGO what issue areas seem to be becoming more relevant and where. Based on what you find, you'll write a short report according to the outline below that demonstrates clearly to the leaders of this NGO which three issues they should prioritize and whether these issues are especially important for certain countries or regions, or are global in scope.

I created an interactive online dashboard called Trends in Global Issues to support your analysis. It lets you explore a country-year dataset with coverage from 1992 to 2022 that tracks metrics ranging from terrorism and nuclear proliferation, to economic development and life expectancy. By setting different options you can show detail by different regions of the world and highlight specific countries. Use what you find with this dashboard to provide data-driven recommendations to the NGO about what issues they should prioritize.

A note on LLM use: I expect you to do your own writing. But you may use an LLM of your choosing to proofread and make suggestions. You could also give an LLM your final paper and my rubric (below) and ask it to check whether your final submission meets all the relevant criteria. You must NOT use an LLM to draft whole sections of text to then pass off as your own. I will run your final submission through AI detection software (like Pangram). I won't automatically fail a group if the software catches AI use, but if the software finds that more than 50% of the document was AI written, I will ask your group to come see me to answer some questions to confirm your understanding of what you produced. We live in a strange world where AI can *produce* a variety of things while the humans directing them bear *responsibility* for the output. If you sign your name to something, you must take full ownership of it.

Here's what your report for the NGO should look like. Each item listed is equally weighted toward your final grade.

Preamble

- Include a title.
- Include the names of your team members.

Introduction

- Include a section header.
- One paragraph.
- Use plain and clear language with no more than two typos or grammatical errors.
- Clearly state your recommendation for the NGO.
- Briefly describe the data you used to support this recommendation.
- Establish the importance of your report: e.g., that you want to help the NGO focus its mission in an evidence-based way.

Analysis

- Include a section header.
- No bullet points or lists.
- 3-5 paragraphs.
- Use plain and clear language with no more than two typos or grammatical errors.
- Include 3-5 data visualizations produced from the Shiny app (you can right-click to copy the visualizations you make and then paste them into your document).
- Each visualization must include a paragraph summarizing it that:
  - Comes *before* the data visualization.
  - Begins with an assertion about what the visualization shows (e.g., "The first issue you should focus on is life expectancy in Sub-Saharan Africa").
  - Includes a summary of how how to "read" the visualization to see how the data supports you assertion.

Conclusion

- Include a section header.
- 1-2 paragraphs.
- Use plain and clear language with no more than two typos or grammatical errors.
- Briefly summarize your recommendations on which three issues to prioritize and whether their scope is global, regional, or even specific to particular countries.
- Think big and discuss why the issues you've identified should matter to the NGO.

Citations

- Any claims or assertions you make (beyond those supported by the data in the Shiny app) should include citations.

- Use in-text hyperlinks to cite sources rather than a conventional citation style.